midnight 17-18 November. The withdrawal had to be coordinated with the FOO stationed at KM 106 so that the artillery guns could then engage the abandoned positions. Battalion HQ minus two companies would redeploy with Brigade HQ at Se-la while the two companies would deploy under 1 Sikh at Se-la itself. The orders were accordingly passed to all sub-units of 4 Garhwal.

Simultaneously, two companies of 4 Sikh LI at Two Lakes were also ordered to fall back and occupy their main positions in the Battalion Defended Area. Ahead of the main defences, one company was to cover the withdrawal of 4 Garhwal and then fall back.

The brigade plan was simple—the covering troops (4 Garhwal Rifles) would henceforth be the brigade reserve while the defences were closed in. At this point, Hoshiar Singh was extremely clear that even if 65 and 48 Brigades were outflanked, 62 Brigade would fight it out. There was absolutely no question of abandoning Se-la and withdrawing from it.

Much as one would like to believe that Anant Pathania was acting purely on the tactical merits of the developing situation, the evidence, including his own statements, are very damning. Most officers who had served with Pathania insist that the man was not a coward, and yet! After ordering Hoshiar Singh to withdraw from Nuranang, the GOC made his call to IV Corps, wanting to speak to Kaul but getting through to the BGS, K. K. Singh, instead.

Anant Pathania's fears, as communicated to IV Corps, were exaggerated. First, at that stage, Hoshiar Singh had definitely not communicated to him that Se-la was being invested from three sides and that his situation was almost untenable. In fact, as Pathania himself admitted after the war, at that stage there was no talk of the Chinese having attacked anything other than Nuranang, though he claims that he did say the situation at Se-la had deteriorated.

Hoshiar Singh had repeatedly underlined his intention to fight it out at Se-la. Apart from repeating this ad nauseam to the men of all five infantry battalions under his command, on 7 November he had sent a letter to all units and sub-units stating: 'The Chinese have ruthlessly attacked our motherland; we must be as ruthless and evict them. This is possible by having an aggressive spirit and a will to win. Se-la is impregnable. We are at a major advantage than the enemy and must be successful: we have a good road, air supply, better and more artillery, and we are fighting on our